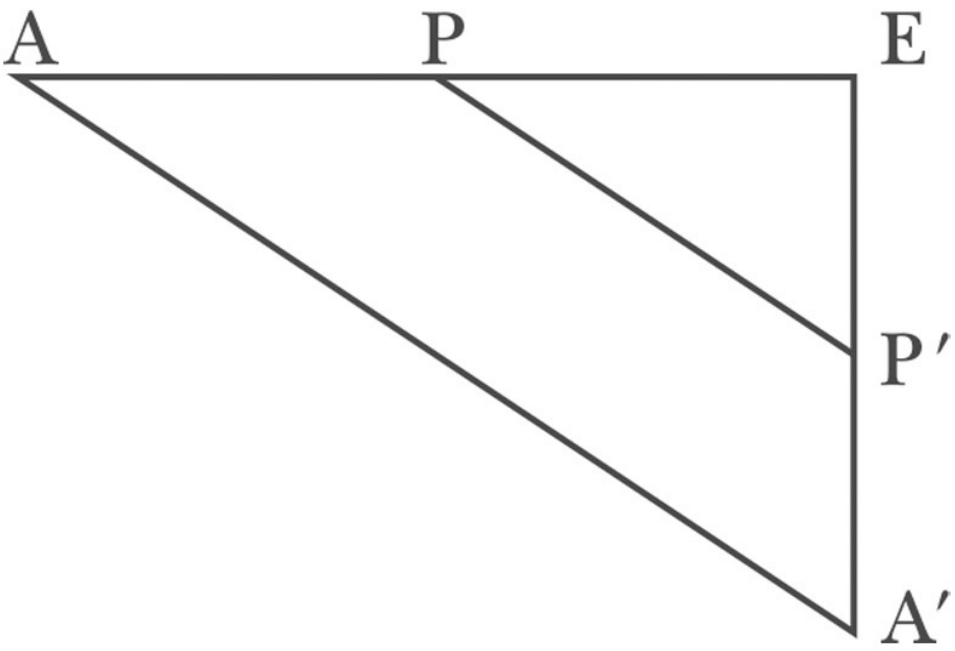


In the wake of Husserl, Martin Heidegger writes—as far as my love of the clarity and transparency of Galileo's writing allows me to decipher the deliberate obscurity of Heidegger's language—that "time temporalizes itself only to the extent that it is human."[115] For him also, time is the time of mankind, the time for doing, for that with which mankind is engaged. Even if, afterward, since he is interested in what being is for man (for "the entity that poses the problem of existence"[116]), Heidegger ends up by identifying the internal consciousness of time as the horizon of being itself.

These intuitions of the degree to which time is inherent to subjectivity remain significant also to any sound naturalism that sees the subject as part of nature and is not afraid to speak about "reality" and to study it—while at the same time acknowledging that our understanding and our intuition are radically filtered by the way in which that limited instrument—our brain—works. This brain is part of that reality that consequently depends on the interaction between an external world and the structures with which the mind operates.

But the mind is the working of our brain. What (little) we are beginning to understand of this functioning is that our entire brain operates on the basis of a collection of *traces* of the past left in the synapses that connect neurons. Synapses are continually formed in their thousands and then erased—especially during sleep, leaving behind a blurry reflection of that which has acted on our nervous system in the past. A blurred image, no doubt—think of how many millions of details our eyes see every moment that do *not* stay in our memory—but one which contains worlds.